

SONGS OF INDIA
Diljit Dosanjh performs at the Coachella music festival last year

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- Films are now being enjoyed without barriers of language or region and collaborations are gaining traction
- One way to incorporate the indie spirit into commercial Indian cinema is by roping in independent filmmakers to direct for mainstream production houses
- Khelo India budget increased to Rs 900 cr. But use of sports science and school and university level competitions for talent growth crucial
- There is also need to have more art schools with vibrant education programmes and to encourage art without prejudice
- India's performing arts are rich and still relevant. What they need is patronage and outreach

tutions to manufacture culture. What we have to do is create institutions that enable expressions that are taking place," says Tasneem Mehta, managing trustee and honorary director of the Bhau Daji Lad Museum based in Mumbai. "Have great museums, great performing art spaces... We have to open our minds." For Mehta, the urgent need is to develop more art schools that have a vibrant education programme and to encourage art without prejudice. "Great quality of art is [when] you can take difficult, fraught issues and present it in moving ways," she says. "It can be a celebration and presentation of the human condition. We can't just pretend we are living in a perfect world." Institutions like the revamped Bharat Mandapam and JSW's Hampi Arts Labs suggest that both the government and private players prioritise arts.

The fine arts scene in the country has grown in the past few years with Indian artworks breaking sales records (see graphic *Indian Art Makes Waves*) and artists like the late Bhupen Khakhar being celebrated at Tate Modern. But the going isn't easy for practitioners of classical performing arts, who find themselves grappling for attention and relevance in a fast-changing world. "Artistes need a regular source of income—employment, pension. The akademis should have a list of the 'needy'," says historian, critic and author Ashish Mohan Khokar. India's performing arts are rich and still relevant, what they need is patronage and outreach. India, says Khokar, needs to take pride in its own culture.

Our growing cultural clout is evident in how Shah Rukh Khan's charisma works in international markets, how Neeraj Chopra's wondrous arm wows the athletics world and that Brand Sabyasachi is renowned globally. The diversity and richness of our cinema and artistic practices and the potential of our young athletes can ensure that India remains top of the conversation. ■